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BIOTECH & HEALTH



**Jury rules Meta violated
California privacy laws by
quietly collecting Flo
users' menstrual health
data**

A California jury [has found](#) Meta in violation of state user privacy laws in a class-action suit brought by users of period tracking app Flo, who alleged that the tech giant collected private menstrual health data without users' consent and used it for ad-tracking purposes.

The plaintiffs, claiming to represent millions of Flo users, had accused Flo and Meta of collecting private health data, like their period dates and fertility goals, via Flo's app without permission, therefore violating California Invasion of Privacy Act.

IMAGE CREDITS:

FILED IN 2021 AGAINST FLO, THE LAWSUIT ALSO NAMED Meta, Google, and ad analytics companies AppsFlyer and Flurry as defendants, though Google [settled the case in July](#), and Flo [did so earlier this month](#).

"This verdict sends a clear message about the protection of digital health data and the responsibilities of Big Tech," said Michael P. Canty and Carol C. Villegas, lead trial attorneys in the case.

"Companies like Meta that covertly profit from users' most intimate information must be held accountable. Today's outcome reinforces the fundamental right to privacy — especially when it comes to sensitive health data," they added.

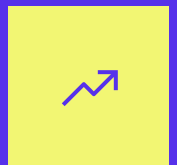
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Meta disagreed with the verdict and said that the company never eavesdropped on Flo users.

“We vigorously disagree with this outcome and are exploring all legal options. The plaintiffs’ claims against Meta are simply false. User privacy is important to Meta, which is why we do not want health or other sensitive information, and why our terms prohibit developers from sending any,” a company spokesperson said in a statement.

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Last year, Flo raised [\\$200 million in Series C funding from General Atlantic](#) at a valuation of over \$1 billion.

Topics: [Biotech & Health](#) [Flo health](#) [Meta](#)

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Ivan Mehta

✕ in

Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Meta starts testing end-to-end encryption for individual Messenger chats

Ivan Mehta — 5:06 AM PDT · August 11, 2022

IMAGE CREDITS: [ANADOLU AGENCY](#) / GETTY IMAGES

Meta said today it is expanding its end-to-end encryption test to individual Messenger chats. The social media giant said that starting this week, people included in the test will have their most

frequent chats automatically protected by end-to-end encryption.

The tech giant’s announcement comes days after it was involved in [a Nebraska case of a teen facing abortion charges](#), where the company turned over her private Facebook Messages to cops. Notably, if these messages were protected by end-to-end encryption, Meta wouldn’t have been able to hand over these details.

Meta first tested end-to-end encryption features for Messenger back in 2016 for “secret conversations.” Later it extended that protection to [voice and video calls in 2021](#). In January, the company introduced [opt-in end-to-end encryption for group chats and calls](#) for Messenger. But unlike Meta’s other popular chat app WhatsApp, end-to-end encryption is not yet enabled by default for all conversations.

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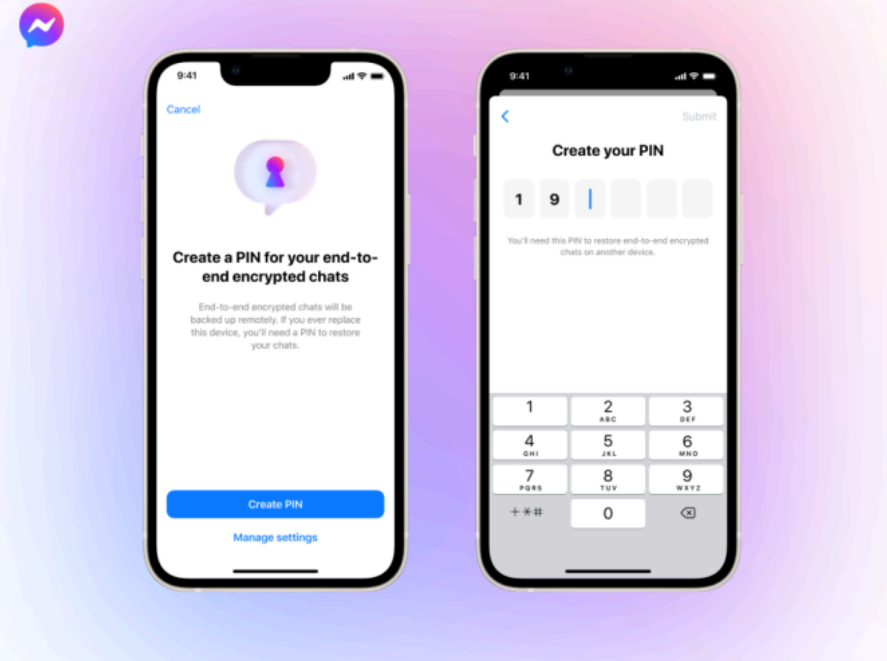


IMAGE CREDITS: META

Secure Storage currently protects only end-to-end chats — like group conversations — on iOS and Android, and is not applicable to non-encrypted chat and Messenger for web and desktop.

After years of criticism, WhatsApp finally started offering [encrypted backup to its 2 billion-plus users last year](#). While the chat app always offered end-to-end encryption protection for chats, its backups were not protected, giving potential access to all the data to law enforcement.

Other tests

Meta also mentioned that it's soon planning to expand its end-to-end encryption test for Instagram DMs. Last year, Instagram started [testing](#) end-to-end encrypted messages through an opt-in setting. In February, the company initially introduced [the feature for all users in Ukraine and Russia](#).

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In another experiment, the social media giant will let users soon unsend encrypted messages and will sync deleted messages across devices.

Last year, Meta said that it expects to roll out [default end-to-end encryption protection across all its apps by 2023](#).

Updated the post with clarification from Meta about group call and chat, and backup keys.

Topics: [encryption](#) [end-to-end encryption](#) [Facebook](#)

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Ivan Mehta

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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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IMAGE CREDITS:

JONATHAN RAA/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

AI



Meta AI is finally coming to the EU, but with limitations

Paul Sawers — 6:35 AM PDT · March 20, 2025

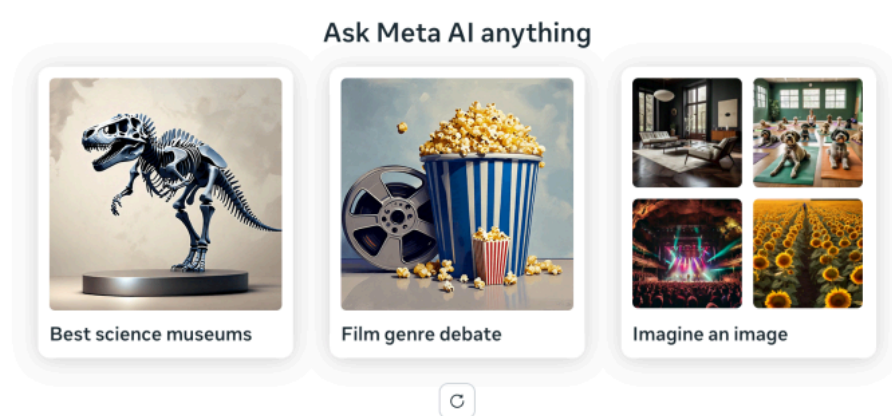
Amid an ongoing regulatory battle with European privacy authorities, Meta [announced](#) on Thursday that its AI-powered virtual assistant, Meta AI, is finally launching in the European Union. The chatbot-like tool will be rolled out across Meta's portfolio of social platforms, albeit with a more limited feature set compared to what it offers in its domestic U.S. market.

Latest in AI

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Separately, Meta also confirmed to TechCrunch that Meta AI will be arriving in WhatsApp in the U.K., having so far been limited to Facebook, Instagram, and Ray-Ban Meta glasses since its launch there in October.

Meta AI has been available in the U.S. [since 2023](#), serving as an AI assistant capable of not just chatting and answering questions, but generating images and creating [stylistic selfies](#), among other [creative wonders](#). These features aren't yet available in the European version.



META AI

IMAGE CREDITS:META

Last month, a chat-based version of Meta AI also [landed in a handful of countries](#) across the Middle East and Africa. And now, starting this week, Meta AI will be rolling out to all 27 EU countries, plus an additional 14 European countries (and 21 overseas territories), including Iceland, Norway, Serbia, and Switzerland.

As well as being able to chat one-to-one with the assistant across Meta's various apps, Meta AI will be made available in group chats, too, although the launch will be staggered — with the feature slated to appear first on WhatsApp, in both the EU and — as noted already — the U.K.

Privacy pushback

AI



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The EU launch of Meta AI marks the latest effort by Facebook’s parent company to spread its AI across the bloc in the face of regulatory concerns about tapping user data to train AI models.

While Meta has been [training its AI](#) on user-generated content in the U.S. for years, the tech giant (among [others](#)) has faced pushback in the EU due to the bloc’s comprehensive [privacy regulations](#) — including the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) — which means it needs to have a valid legal basis to process people’s information to train AI models.



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Despite these challenges, last May Meta [began notifying regional users](#) of an upcoming privacy policy change that informed them it would start using content from their comments, interactions, status updates, photos, and captions for AI training. The company [argued](#) that this data processing was necessary for its AI model to reflect “the diverse

languages, geography and cultural references of the people in Europe.”

However, in June, Meta was compelled to [put these plans on ice](#) following scrutiny by the Irish Data Protection Commission (DPC), Meta’s lead data protection regulator in the EU, which raised concerns about the way Meta was soliciting consent from users to process their data.

In short, Meta had implemented an onerous opt-out process (meaning users had to take action to prevent their data from becoming AI training fodder) rather than a simple opt-in — with the company relying on a GDPR legal basis known as “legitimate interests,” claiming its actions were compliant with the law. However the DPC disagreed and Meta was forced to rethink its approach.

The company confirmed to TechCrunch that the version of the AI assistant it’s launching in the EU has not been trained on local users’ data — hence why it said it won’t be notifying users or otherwise seeking their consent, since it claims the technology has not been trained on their information.

“The model powering these Meta AI features wasn’t trained on first-party data from users in the EU,” Anna Dack, Meta’s innovation communications manager, EMEA, told TechCrunch.

Meta initially faced similar regulatory concerns in the U.K., which (since Brexit) sits outside the EU — but does still have a data protection regime that’s based on the GDPR.

Last summer, the U.K.’s Information Commissioner’s Office (ICO) [asked Meta to pause its AI training plans](#) over concerns about how it was helping itself to user data. But after the company [adjusted its opt-out process](#), making it [mildly less](#)

onerous, Meta went on to [launch Meta AI in the U.K.](#) — without explicit objection from the U.K. regulator, though the [ICO said it would “monitor the situation.”](#)

When asked if Meta’s AI efforts were yet trained on U.K. users’ data, a spokesperson directed TechCrunch to its [announcement post](#) back in September, where it said that it will begin training its models on user content “in the coming months,” suggesting that it’s not yet ready for the public stage.

“Intelligent chat”

For now, Meta AI in the EU will be limited to what the company bills as an “intelligent chat function” in six European languages: English, French, Spanish, Portuguese, German, and Italian.

As it stands, the tool is basically a chatbot baked into Meta’s various apps, including WhatsApp, Instagram, Messenger, and Facebook itself. How it works is you tap a little blue circle icon to summon the assistant, and ask it any question that you might ask in a search engine, such as how to carry out a task, or to find out information on a topic.

As noted above, the feature will also be landing in group chats but this launch is being staggered — starting with WhatsApp, before expanding to Messenger and Instagram Direct Messaging “soon.”

Users will be able to call on the assistant by typing “@MetaAI,” and then asking a question — for example, where to go for dinner, or the top tourist attraction in a given city.

META AI

IMAGE CREDITS: META

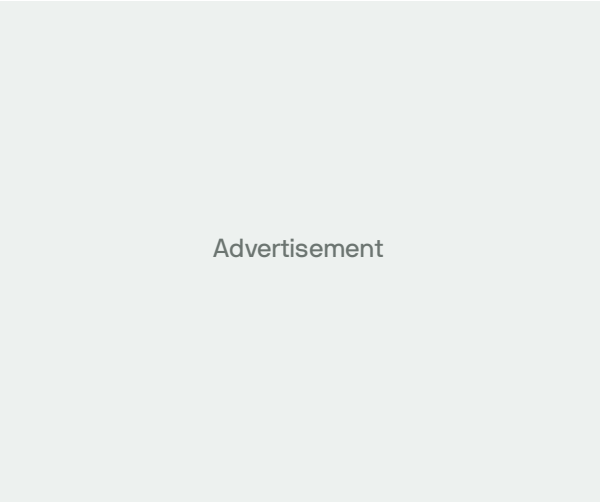
While Meta says in its announcement that Meta AI has “an advanced understanding of what you’re looking for,” it says this is not in reference to any kind of personalized suggestions based on the user’s data; the marketing claim is merely in the context of searching for content more easily and intuitively, it suggests.

However, the company does stress that this launch represents its “first step” in its efforts to bring more AI to Europe, and that it plans to eventually “find parity with the U.S.” over time. What this likely means is more tussles between Meta — which [has been critical](#) of Europe’s AI regulations — and EU regulators.

TechCrunch reached out to the DPC to ask for its response to the Meta AI for EU announcement.

“The DPC, as Lead Supervisory Authority for Meta, has been examining Meta AI over recent months with our colleague Supervisory Authorities across the EU/EEA and we will keep it under review as it rolls-out to users over the coming weeks,” a spokesperson told us.

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Paul Sawers

Senior Reporter | [X](#)

Paul was a senior TechCrunch writer based in London, who focused largely (but not exclusively) on the world of UK a...

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